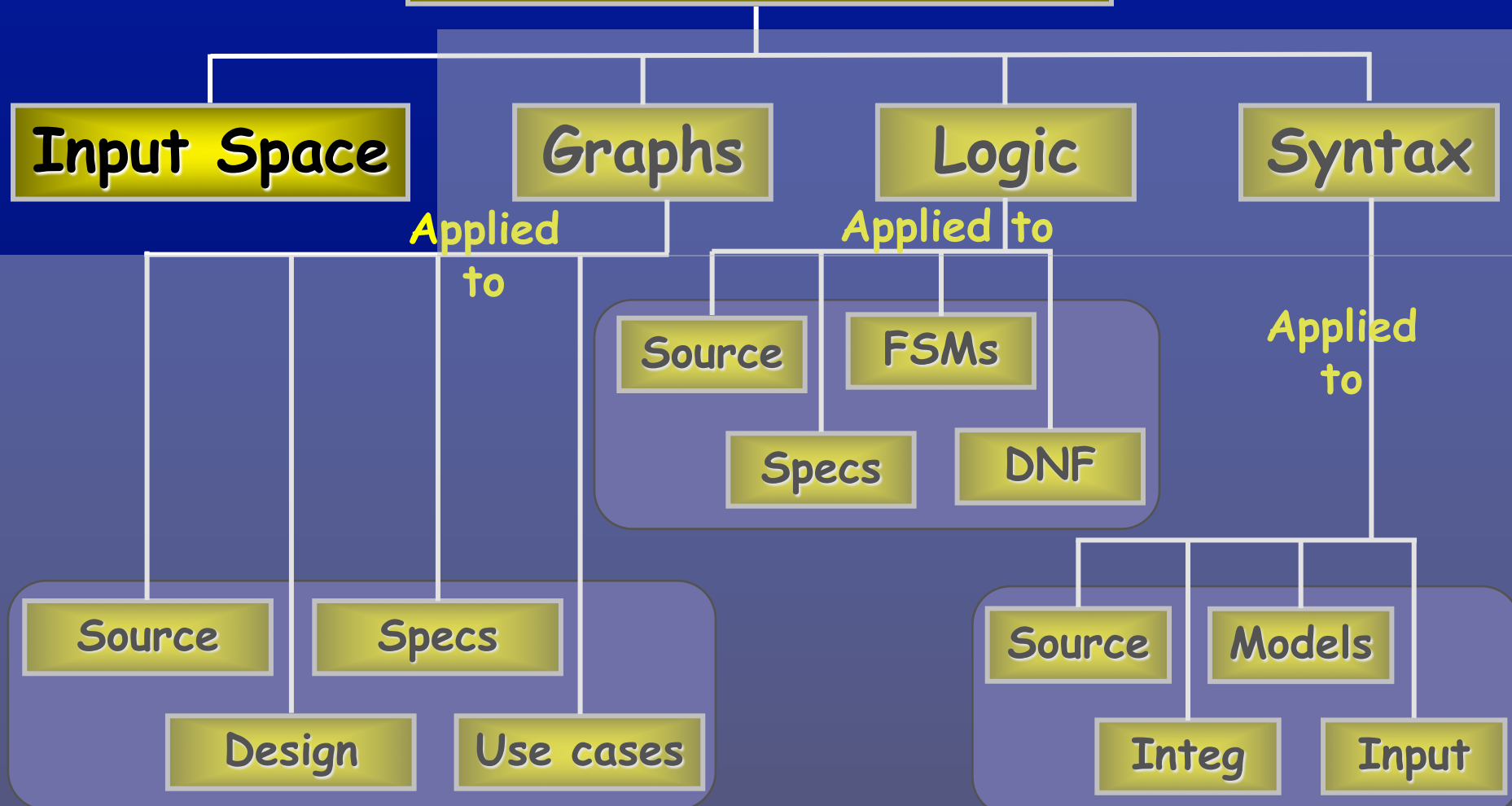


Introduction to Software Testing Chapter 6 Input Space Partition Testing

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Ch. 6 : Input Space Coverage

Four Structures for Modeling Software



Benefits of ISP

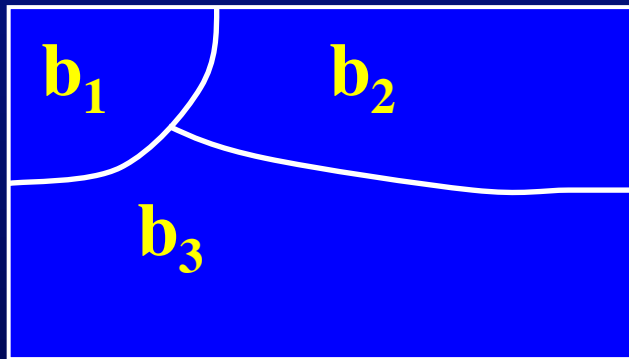
- Can be **equally applied** at several levels of testing
 - Unit
 - Integration
 - System
- Relatively easy to apply with **no automation**
- Easy to **adjust** the procedure to get more or fewer tests
- No **implementation knowledge** is needed
 - Just the input space

Input Domains

- The **input domain** for a program contains all the possible inputs to that program
- For even small programs, the input domain is so large that it might as well be **infinite**
- Testing is fundamentally about **choosing finite sets** of values from the input domain
- **Input parameters** define the scope of the input domain
 - Parameters to a method
 - Data read from a file
 - Global variables
 - User level inputs
- Input domains are **partitioned into regions** (blocks)
- At least **one value** is chosen from each block

Partitioning Domains

- Domain D
- Partition scheme q of D
- The partition q defines a set of blocks, $B_q = b_1, b_2, \dots, b_Q$
- The partition must satisfy two properties :
 1. Blocks must be *pairwise disjoint* (no overlap)
 2. Together the blocks *cover* the domain D (complete)



$$b_i \cap b_j = \Phi, \forall i \neq j, b_i, b_j \in B_q$$

$$\bigcup_{b \in B_q} b = D$$

Using Partitions – Assumptions

- Choose a **value** from each block
- Each value is assumed to be **equally useful** for testing
- Application to testing
 - Find **characteristics** in the inputs : parameters, semantic descriptions, ...
 - **Partition** each characteristic
 - **Choose tests** by combining values from characteristics
- Example **Characteristics**
 - Input X is null
 - Order of the input file F (sorted, inverse sorted, arbitrary, ...)
 - Min separation of two aircraft
 - Input device (DVD, CD, VCR, computer, ...)

Choosing Partitions

- Choosing (or defining) **partitions** seems easy, but is easy to get wrong
- Consider the “*order of file F*”

b_1 = sorted in ascending order
 b_2 = sorted in descending order
 b_3 = arbitrary order

but ... something's fishy ...

What if the file is of length 1?

The file will be in all three blocks ...
That is, disjointness is not satisfied

Solution:

Each characteristic should address just one property

C1: File F sorted ascending

- $c1.b1 = \text{true}$
- $c1.b2 = \text{false}$

C2: File F sorted descending

- $c2.b1 = \text{true}$
- $c2.b2 = \text{false}$

Properties of Partitions

- If the partitions are not **complete** or **disjoint**, that means the partitions have not been considered carefully enough
- They should be reviewed carefully, like any **design**
- Different **alternatives** should be considered
- We model the input domain in **five steps** ...
 - Steps 1 and 2 move us from the implementation abstraction level to the design abstraction level (from chapter 2)
 - Steps 3 & 4 are entirely at the design abstraction level
 - Step 5 brings us back down to the implementation abstraction level

Modeling the Input Domain

- **Step 1** : Identify testable **functions**
 - Individual **methods** have one testable function
 - Methods in a **class** often have the same characteristics
 - **Programs** have more complicated characteristics—modeling documents such as UML can be used to design characteristics
 - **Systems** of integrated hardware and software components can use devices, operating systems, hardware platforms, browsers, etc.
- **Step 2** : Find all the **parameters**
 - Often fairly **straightforward**, even mechanical
 - Important to be **complete**
 - **Methods** : Parameters and state (non-local) variables used
 - **Components** : Parameters to methods and state variables
 - **System** : All inputs, including files and databases

Modeling the Input Domain (*cont*)

- **Step 3** : Model the input domain
 - The domain is scoped by the parameters
 - The structure is defined in terms of characteristics
 - Each characteristic is partitioned into sets of blocks
 - Each block represents a set of values
 - This is the most creative design step in using ISP
- **Step 4** : Apply a test criterion to choose combinations of values
 - A test input has a value for each parameter
 - One block for each characteristic
 - Choosing all combinations is usually infeasible
 - Coverage criteria allow subsets to be chosen
- **Step 5** : Refine combinations of blocks into test inputs
 - Choose appropriate values from each block

Two Approaches to Input Domain Modeling

1. Interface-based approach

- Develops characteristics directly from **individual input** parameters
- **Simplest** application
- Can be **partially automated** in some situations

2. Functionality-based approach

- Develops characteristics from a **behavioral view** of the program under test
- **Harder** to develop—requires more design effort
- May result in **better tests**, or fewer tests that are as effective

Input Domain Model (IDM)

1. Interface-Based Approach

- Mechanically consider each parameter in isolation
- This is an easy modeling technique and relies mostly on syntax
- Some domain and semantic information won't be used
 - Could lead to an incomplete IDM
- Ignores relationships among parameters

1. Interface-Based Example

- Consider method *triang()* from class *TriangleType* on the book website :
 - <http://www.cs.gmu.edu/~offutt/softwaretest/java/Triangle.java>
 - <http://www.cs.gmu.edu/~offutt/softwaretest/java/TriangleType.java>

```
public enum Triangle { Scalene, Isosceles, Equilateral, Invalid }  
public static Triangle triang (int Side, int Side2, int Side3)  
// Side1, Side2, and Side3 represent the lengths of the sides of a triangle  
// Returns the appropriate enum value
```

The IDM for each parameter is identical

Reasonable characteristic : *Relation of side with zero*

2. Functionality-Based Approach

- Identify characteristics that correspond to the intended **functionality**
- Requires more **design effort** from tester
- Can incorporate **domain** and **semantic** knowledge
- Can use **relationships** among parameters
- Modeling can be based on **requirements**, not implementation
- The same parameter may appear in multiple characteristics, so it's **harder** to translate values to test cases

2. Functionality-Based Example

- Again, consider method *triang()* from class *TriangleType* :

The three parameters represent a *triangle*

The IDM can combine all parameters

Reasonable characteristic : *Type of triangle*

Steps 1 & 2—Identifying Functionalities, Parameters and Characteristics

- A creative engineering step
- More characteristics means more tests
- Interface-based : Translate parameters to characteristics
- Candidates for characteristics :
 - Preconditions and postconditions
 - Relationships among variables
 - Relationship of variables with special values (zero, null, blank, ...)
- Should not use program source—characteristics should be based on the input domain
 - Program source should be used with graph or logic criteria
- Better to have more characteristics with few blocks
 - Fewer mistakes and fewer tests

Steps 1 & 2—Interface & Functionality-Based

```
public boolean findElement (List list, Object element)
// Effects: if list or element is null throw NullPointerException
//          else return true if element is in the list, false otherwise
```

Interface-Based Approach

Two parameters : list, element

Characteristics :

list is null (block1 = true, block2 = false)

list is empty (block1 = true, block2 = false)

Functionality-Based Approach

Two parameters : list, element

Characteristics :

number of occurrences of element in list
(0, 1, >1)

element occurs first in list
(true, false)

element occurs last in list
(true, false)

Step 3 : Modeling the Input Domain

- Partitioning characteristics into blocks and values is a very **creative engineering** step
- **More blocks** means more tests
- Partitioning often flows directly from the definition of **characteristics** and both steps are done together
 - Should **evaluate** them separately – sometimes fewer characteristics can be used with more blocks and vice versa
- **Strategies** for identifying values :
 - Include **valid**, **invalid** and **special** values
 - **Sub-partition** some blocks
 - Explore **boundaries** of domains
 - Include values that represent “**normal use**”
 - Try to **balance** the number of blocks in each characteristic
 - Check for **completeness** and **disjointness**

Interface-Based –*triang()*

- *triang()* has one testable function and three integer inputs

First Characterization of TriTyp's Inputs

Characteristic	b_1	b_2	b_3
q_1 = "Relation of Side 1 to 0"	greater than 0	equal to 0	less than 0
q_2 = "Relation of Side 2 to 0"	greater than 0	equal to 0	less than 0
q_3 = "Relation of Side 3 to 0"	greater than 0	equal to 0	less than 0

- A maximum of $3*3*3 = 27$ tests
- Some triangles are **valid**, some are **invalid**
- **Refining** the characterization can lead to more tests ...

Interface-Based IDM—*triang()*

Second Characterization of *triang()*'s Inputs

Characteristic	b_1	b_2	b_3	b_4
q_1 = "Refinement of q_1 "	greater than 1	equal to 1	equal to 0	less than 0
q_2 = "Refinement of q_2 "	greater than 1	equal to 1	equal to 0	less than 0
q_3 = "Refinement of q_3 "	greater than 1	equal to 1	equal to 0	less than 0

- A maximum of $4*4*4 = 64$ tests
- **Complete** because the inputs are integers (0 .. 1)

Possible values for partition q_1

Characteristic	b_1	b_2	b_3	b_4
Side 1	2	1	0	-1

Test boundary conditions

Functionality-Based *IDM–triang()*

- First two characterizations are based on **syntax**–parameters and their type
- A **semantic** level characterization could use the fact that the three integers represent a triangle

Geometric Characterization of *triang()*'s Inputs

Characteristic	b_1	b_2	b_3	b_4
q_1 = "Geometric Classification"	scalene	isosceles	equilateral	invalid

- Oops ... something's **fishy** ... equilateral is also isosceles !
- We need to **refine** the example to make characteristics valid

Correct Geometric Characterization of *triang()*'s Inputs

Characteristic	b_1	b_2	b_3	b_4
q_1 = "Geometric Classification"	scalene	isosceles, not equilateral	equilateral	invalid

Functionality-Based IDM—*triang()*

- **Values** for this partitioning can be chosen as

Possible values for geometric partition q_i

Characteristic	b_1	b_2	b_3	b_4
Triangle	(4, 5, 6)	(3, 3, 4)	(3, 3, 3)	(3, 4, 8)

Functionality-Based IDM—*triang()*

- A **different approach** would be to break the geometric characterization into four separate characteristics

Four Characteristics for *triang()*

Characteristic	b_1	b_2
$q_1 = \text{"Scalene"}$	True	False
$q_2 = \text{"Isosceles"}$	True	False
$q_3 = \text{"Equilateral"}$	True	False
$q_4 = \text{"Valid"}$	True	False

- Use **constraints** to ensure that
 - **Equilateral = True** implies **Isosceles = True**
 - **Valid = False** implies **Scalene = Isosceles = Equilateral = False**

Using More than One IDM

- Some programs may have dozens or even hundreds of parameters
- Create **several** small IDMs
 - A divide-and-conquer approach
- Different parts of the software can be tested with different amounts of **rigor**
 - For example, some IDMs may include a lot of invalid values
- It is okay if the different IDMs **overlap**
 - The same variable may appear in more than one IDM

Step 4 – Choosing Combinations of Values (6.2)

- Once characteristics and partitions are defined, the next step is to **choose test values**
- We use **criteria** – to choose **effective** subsets
- The most obvious criterion is to choose all combinations

All Combinations (ACoC) : All combinations of blocks from all characteristics must be used.

- Number of tests is the product of the number of blocks in each characteristic : $\prod_{i=1}^Q (B_i)$
- The second characterization of triang() results in $4*4*4 =$ **64 tests**
 - Too many ?

ISP Criteria – All Combinations

- Consider the “second characterization” of Triang as given before:

Characteristic	b_1	b_2	b_3	b_4
q_1 = “Refinement of q_1 ”	greater than 1	equal to 1	equal to 0	less than 0
q_2 = “Refinement of q_2 ”	greater than 1	equal to 1	equal to 0	less than 0
q_3 = “Refinement of q_3 ”	greater than 1	equal to 1	equal to 0	less than 0

- For convenience, we relabel the blocks:

Characteristic	b_1	b_2	b_3	b_4
A	A1	A2	A3	A4
B	B1	B2	B3	B4
C	C1	C2	C3	C4

ISP Criteria – ACoC Tests

A1 B1 C1	A2 B1 C1	A3 B1 C1	A4 B1 C1
A1 B1 C2	A2 B1 C2	A3 B1 C2	A4 B1 C2
A1 B1 C3	A2 B1 C3	A3 B1 C3	A4 B1 C3
A1 B1 C4	A2 B1 C4	A3 B1 C4	A4 B1 C4
A1 B2 C1	A2 B2 C1	A3 B2 C1	A4 B2 C1
A1 B2 C2	A2 B2 C2	A3 B2 C2	A4 B2 C2
A1 B2 C3	A2 B2 C3	A3 B2 C3	A4 B2 C3
A1 B2 C4	A2 B2 C4	A3 B2 C4	A4 B2 C4
A1 B3 C1	A2 B3 C1	A3 B3 C1	A4 B3 C1
A1 B3 C2	A2 B3 C2	A3 B3 C2	A4 B3 C2
A1 B3 C3	A2 B3 C3	A3 B3 C3	A4 B3 C3
A1 B3 C4	A2 B3 C4	A3 B3 C4	A4 B3 C4
A1 B4 C1	A2 B4 C1	A3 B4 C1	A4 B4 C1
A1 B4 C2	A2 B4 C2	A3 B4 C2	A4 B4 C2
A1 B4 C3	A2 B4 C3	A3 B4 C3	A4 B4 C3
A1 B4 C4	A2 B4 C4	A3 B4 C4	A4 B4 C4

ACoC yields
 $4*4*4 = 64$ tests
for Triang!

This is almost
certainly more
than we need

Only 8 are valid
(all sides greater
than zero)

ISP Criteria – Each Choice

- 64 tests for `triang()` is almost certainly way too many
- One criterion comes from the idea that we should try at **least one** value from each block

Each Choice Coverage (ECC) : One value from each block for each characteristic must be used in at least one test case.

- Number of tests is the number of blocks in the largest characteristic : $\text{Max}_{i=1}^Q (B_i)$

For *triang()* : A1, B1, C1

A2, B2, C2

A3, B3, C3

A4, B4, C4

Substituting values: 2, 2, 2

1, 1, 1

0, 0, 0

-1, -1, -1

ISP Criteria – Pair-Wise

- Each choice yields few tests—**cheap** but maybe ineffective
- Another approach **combines** values with other values

Pair-Wise Coverage (PWC) : A value from each block for each characteristic must be combined with a value from every block for each other characteristic.

- Number of tests is at least the product of two largest characteristics $(\text{Max}_{i=1}^Q (B_i)) * (\text{Max}_{j=1, j \neq i}^Q (B_j))$

For *triang()* :

A1, B1, C1	A1, B2, C2	A1, B3, C3	A1, B4, C4
A2, B1, C2	A2, B2, C3	A2, B3, C4	A2, B4, C1
A3, B1, C3	A3, B2, C4	A3, B3, C1	A3, B4, C2
A4, B1, C4	A4, B2, C1	A4, B3, C2	A4, B4, C3

ISP Criteria –T-Wise

- A natural extension is to require combinations of t values instead of 2

t-Wise Coverage (TWC) : A value from each block for each group of t characteristics must be combined.

- Number of tests is at least the product of t largest characteristics
- If all characteristics are the same size, the formula is

$$(\text{Max}_{i=1}^Q (B_i))^t$$

- If t is the number of characteristics Q , then all combinations
- That is ... $Q\text{-wise} = AC$
- t -wise is **expensive** and benefits are not clear

ISP Criteria – Base Choice

- Testers sometimes recognize that certain values are **important**
- This uses **domain knowledge** of the program

Base Choice Coverage (BCC) : A base choice block is chosen for each characteristic, and a base test is formed by using the base choice for each characteristic. Subsequent tests are chosen by holding all but one base choice constant and using each non-base choice in each other characteristic.

- Number of tests is one base test + one test for each other block $1 + \sum_{i=1}^Q (B_i - 1)$

For <i>triang()</i> : <u>Base</u>	A1, B1, C1	A1, B1, C2	A1, B2, C1	A2, B1, C1
		A1, B1, C3	A1, B3, C1	A3, B1, C1
		A1, B1, C4	A1, B4, C1	A4, B1, C1

Base Choice Notes

- The base test must be **feasible**
 - That is, all base choices must be **compatible**
- **Base choices** can be
 - Most likely from an end-use point of view
 - Simplest
 - Smallest
 - First in some ordering
- **Happy path** tests often make good base choices
- The base choice is a **crucial design** decision
 - Test designers should **document** why the choices were made

ISP Criteria – Multiple Base Choice

- We sometimes have more than one logical base choice

Multiple Base Choice Coverage (MBCC) : At least one, and possibly more, base choice blocks are chosen for each characteristic, and base tests are formed by using each base choice for each characteristic at least once. Subsequent tests are chosen by holding all but one base choice constant for each base test and using each non-base choice in each other characteristic.

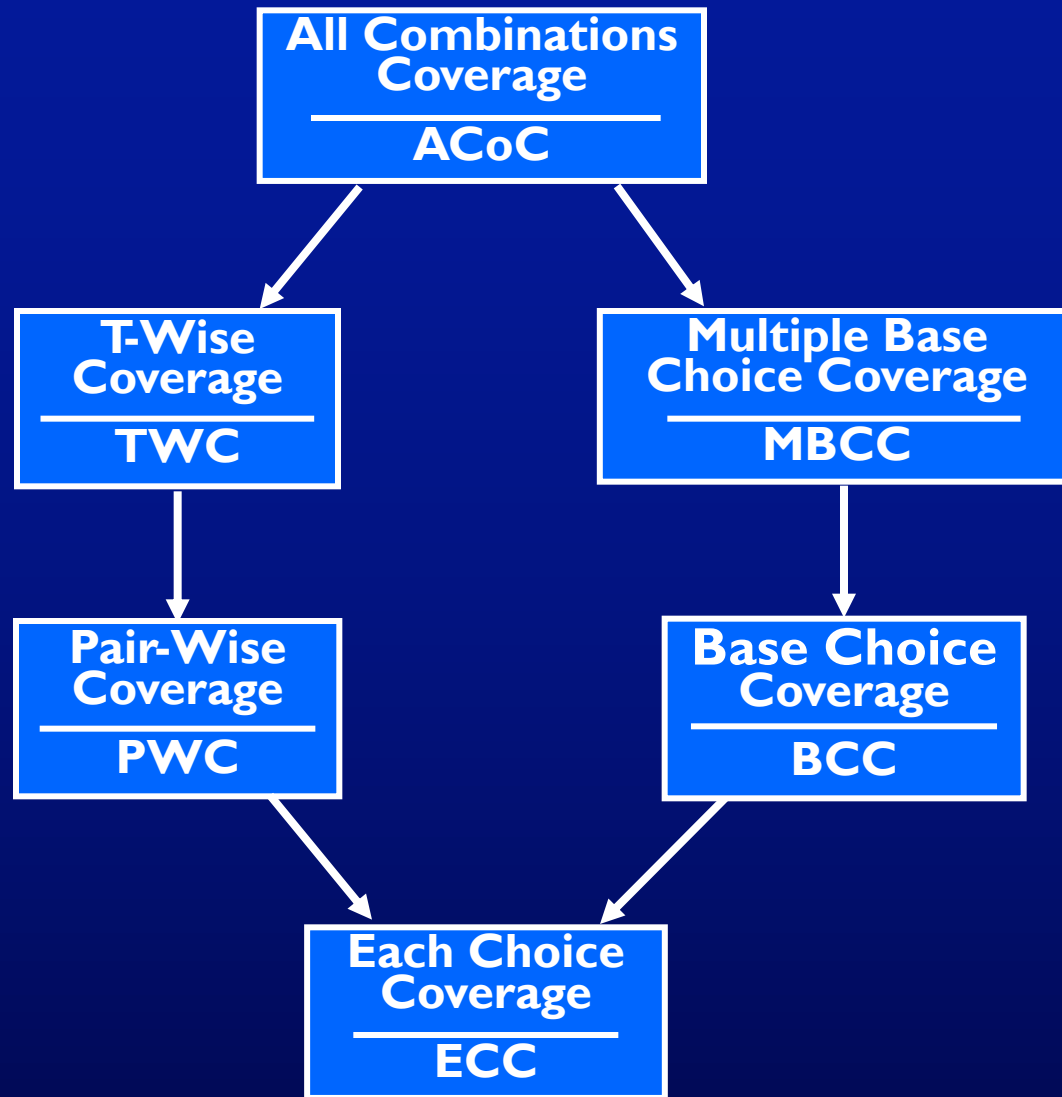
- If **M** base tests and **m_i** base choices for each characteristic:

$$M + \sum_{i=1}^Q (M * (B_i - m_i))$$

For *triang()* : Bases

A1, B1, C1	A1, B1, C3	A1, B3, C1	A3, B1, C1
	A1, B1, C4	A1, B4, C1	A4, B1, C1
A2, B2, C2	A2, B2, C3	A2, B3, C2	A3, B2, C2
	A2, B2, C4	A2, B4, C2	A4, B2, C2

ISP Coverage Criteria Subsumption



Constraints Among Characteristics (6.3)

- Some combinations of blocks are **infeasible**
 - “less than zero” and “scalene” ... not possible at the same time
- These are represented as **constraints** among blocks
- Two general types of constraints
 - A block from one characteristic **cannot be** combined with a specific block from another
 - A block from one characteristic can **ONLY BE** combined with a specific block from another characteristic
- Handling constraints depends on the criterion used
 - **ACC, PWC, TWC** : Drop the infeasible pairs
 - **BCC, MBCC** : Change a value to another non-base choice to find a feasible combination

Example Handling Constraints

```
public boolean findElement (List list, Object element)
// Effects: if list or element is null throw NullPointerException
//         else return true if element is in the list, false otherwise
```

Characteristic	Block 1	Block 2	Block 3	Block 4
A : length and contents	One element	More than one, unsorted	More than one, sorted	More than one, all identical
B : match	element not found	element found once	element found more than once	
Invalid combinations : (A1, B3), (A4, B2)				

element cannot be in a one-element list more than once

If the list only has one element, but it appears multiple times, we cannot find it just once

Input Space Partitioning Summary

- Fairly easy to apply, even with **no automation**
- Convenient ways to **add more or less** testing
- Applicable to **all levels** of testing – unit, class, integration, system, etc.
- Based only on the **input space** of the program, not the implementation

**Simple, straightforward, effective,
and widely used**